

**SYNTHETIC TRAINING RECORD — FICTIONAL PARTIES, PEOPLE,
OFFICES, IDENTIFIERS, AND EVENTS — NOT A REAL FILING**

Answer

United States District Court for the Eastern District of North Carolina

Rhea Calder v. Cinder Lake Health Network, Inc.

Civil Action No. SYN-EDNC-25-CV-0882

Docket Entry 8 — Filed December 22, 2025

Defendant Cinder Lake Health Network, Inc. answers the First Amended Complaint. It admits only that Calder worked as a compliance analyst, raised concerns during June 2025, received a performance notice, and was discharged on September 12, 2025. It denies retaliation and denies that any adverse action occurred because of protected activity.

Cinder Lake states that its response to Calder's reports included an attorney-directed review and operational remediation. It does not plead advice of counsel as a defense and does not disclose the content of legal advice.

Responses to Parties and Jurisdiction

Cinder Lake admits it is a fictional North Carolina health-services organization and that Calder worked in its Raleigh administrative office. It admits the Court may exercise federal-question jurisdiction over Calder's pleaded § 3730(h) claim and does not contest venue for this exercise.

It denies any allegation implying that participation in a federal program establishes a billing violation. It lacks knowledge sufficient to admit Calder's characterization of her personal purpose when making reports and therefore denies that characterization. References to real agencies, beneficiaries, providers, or accounts are neither alleged nor admitted.

Responses to Billing-Report Allegations

Cinder Lake admits Calder delivered written reports on June 4 and June 18, 2025, and participated in a June 27 compliance interview. It admits the reports concerned exceptions in federal-program billing records. It denies that the exceptions necessarily reflected false claims or knowing misconduct.

Cinder Lake admits that ordinary business records and nonprivileged facts concerning the exceptions may be discoverable subject to relevance, proportionality, and other objections. It denies that acknowledgment opens attorney communications, attorney-directed interview materials, or legal analysis to categorical discovery.

Responses Concerning the Review

Cinder Lake admits that it retained fictional outside counsel Rowan Vale to direct a confidential internal review. Employees were asked to provide facts so counsel could advise the organization about legal exposure, reporting duties, and remediation. The review also anticipated possible litigation following Calder's accusations.

The organization does not reveal any question asked, answer given, note recorded, legal conclusion reached, or recommendation communicated. Its answer describes purpose and structure only to preserve the distinction between ordinary business facts and protected attorney-client communications or work product.

August 21 Letter

Cinder Lake admits it sent a compliance response to a fictional federal health-program oversight office on August 21, 2025. The response stated that outside counsel reviewed Calder's reports and that Cinder Lake adopted identified remedial measures. It denies that the letter quoted or summarized counsel's communications, witness communications, mental impressions, or legal analysis.

Cinder Lake denies that announcing the fact of a review, its general conclusions, or corporate action waived privilege over the investigation. It pleads no advice-of-counsel defense and will not use undisclosed advice as a sword to establish a merits defense.

Employment Decisions

Cinder Lake admits issuing a performance notice on July 18 and ending Calder's employment on September 12. It denies that either decision was retaliatory. It alleges the decisions followed documented concerns about collaboration, deadline management, and compliance with ordinary reporting practices that were independent of Calder's protected reports.

Cinder Lake denies changing its explanation and denies removing Calder from meetings as punishment. It admits that some responsibilities changed while the organization separated Calder from records under active review. Whether those actions were legitimate or pretextual is a merits issue for discovery and trial.

Specific Denials and Reservation

Cinder Lake denies that Calder has established protected activity, knowledge, causation, damages, or entitlement to relief. It denies all allegations not expressly admitted. It reserves the right to amend its defenses as permitted after discovery.

The reservation is not a claim that privilege extends to underlying facts. Cinder Lake will identify responsive custodial records and witnesses, make document-specific claims where protection applies, and provide the information required for a privilege log. It opposes any inference that an entire subject becomes discoverable merely because nonprivileged facts are disclosed.

Affirmative Defenses

Without assuming a burden it does not bear, Cinder Lake alleges legitimate nonretaliatory reasons for the challenged actions, failure to mitigate to the extent proven, and limits on remedies imposed by law. It also preserves objections based on relevance, proportionality, privilege, work product, and confidentiality.

These defenses do not rely on the substance of counsel's advice. Cinder Lake will not argue that it acted lawfully because counsel approved its conduct. It instead intends to prove its employment reasons through nonprivileged records and testimony.

Requested Judgment

Cinder Lake requests that Calder take nothing, that judgment enter in its favor, and that costs be awarded as permitted. It requests no ruling at this stage on a particular discovery document and no categorical protective order beyond ordinary procedural rights.

The organization recognizes that the Court may later distinguish protected communications from discoverable facts. It asks that any such decision be based on the content and purpose of particular materials rather than a broad subject label.

Signature and Service

Submitted December 22, 2025 by **Mara Voss**, fictional counsel for Cinder Lake Health Network, Inc. Voss certifies service through the synthetic civil-filing channel on Nina Ashe, fictional counsel for Rhea Calder.

This answer concerns only Civil Action No. SYN-EDNC-25-CV-0882. It neither represents a real filing nor describes a real health network, employee, counsel, patient, billing record, or government investigation.